



For Staff

Student Using Racist Language Toward Another

Responding when you witness racist comments and slurs aimed at a student, in front of others

Content Warning This guide covers racist and faith-targeted abuse between students.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of racist and faith-targeted abuse, slurs (described, never written out), stereotypes and hate crime, and their impact on young people. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561).
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

Racism is the most common motive in hate crime recorded by the police: in the year ending March 2025, **race hate crimes made up 71% of police-recorded hate crimes in England and Wales (82,490 offences)**, and religious hate crimes targeted at Muslims rose by 19% ([Home Office, 2025](#)). The Community Security Trust recorded **204 antisemitic incidents affecting people and buildings in the school sector** in 2025 ([CST, 2026](#)). There are no current official national figures on racist incidents in schools, which is one reason why each school's own recording matters.

KCSIE 2026 is clear that this is a safeguarding matter as well as a behaviour matter. Staff should recognise that racism and faith-targeted abuse may affect a child's welfare, mental health, sense of safety and willingness to seek help (paragraphs 17 and 32). Discriminatory behaviour, including racism, faith-targeted abuse and other prejudice-based incidents, is child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37). Schools should promote an anti-discriminatory culture where racism is "recognised, challenged and addressed" as part of their safeguarding responsibilities (paragraph 119). [Working Together 2026](#) puts it simply: effective safeguarding is anti-discriminatory and anti-racist.

Scenario Overview

During break time, you overhear a student making racist comments and using derogatory slurs toward a classmate. Other students are watching, and the targeted student appears upset but isn't responding.

What to Keep in Mind

- **You witnessed it, so no disclosure is needed.** Act now: stop it, if it is safe to do so, and tell the DSL the same day.
- **Silence is not the same as being OK.** Freezing, going quiet or laughing along are common responses to public abuse. Support the student targeted first.
- **Name it without repeating it.** Never repeat a slur aloud, even to challenge it.
- **Bystanders matter.** An audience changes the harm and the risk. Move the crowd on, and notice who is filming.
- **Behaviour, safeguarding and possibly crime overlap.** You don't need to decide which this is. Staff never decide whether an offence has been committed.

- A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before acting or reporting.
- The student who used the language is **a child too**: they need accountability and education, and the adults need to understand what sits behind it.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral: walking past teaches everyone watching that racism is allowed), **Contextual Safeguarding** (racism runs through peer groups, group chats and online content) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (safety and dignity before questions). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan; No Disclosure Needed	Slurs in public, an audience, a silent student: racist abuse and child-on-child abuse
● Engage	Stop it, if it is safe to do so; TED; the disclosure script	Name it without repeating it; move the crowd; go to the student targeted
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Somewhere quiet, a trusted adult, dignity; separate the students
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources)	No debate, no forced apology, no interrogating witnesses; check your own bias
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	Explain what happens next; options, not orders; bystanders: Delegate, Distract, Delay
● Notify	DSL as soon as is practicably possible, the same day; immediately where there is immediate risk; 999 for immediate danger	Include the filming, the crowd and any earlier incidents
● Document	GOLD standard	What was said and done, who was present, how the student responded, what you did

RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response and escalation on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count. Here, the student targeted, and everyone watching, will learn from this one moment whether adults act.

The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

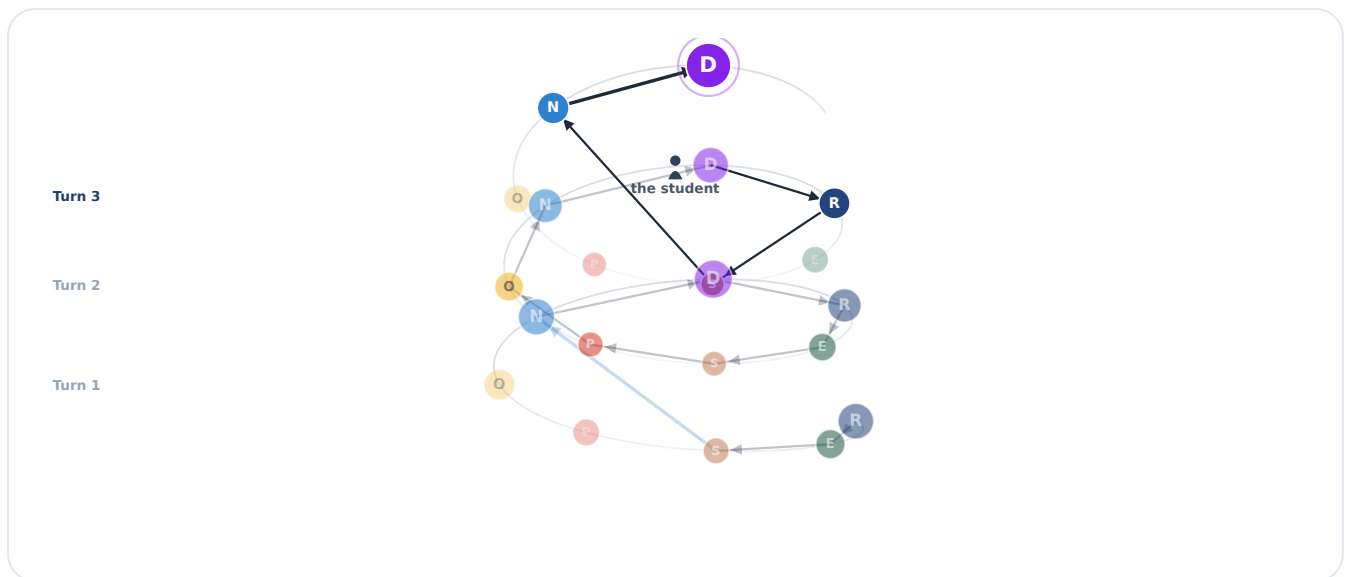
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

One example: "jokes" about a student's heritage that become racist abuse at break, then online. Then see a wider spiral, with the crowd involved, and what happens when steps are skipped.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Racist language often starts as "jokes" that nobody challenges, then becomes targeted, public and online. When you witness it, you act and support in the moment, then Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

From jokes to a pattern

A Year 9 student is the target of comments about his heritage over half a term. The helix wraps around him.

1. **Turn 1: the "jokes":** A teacher hears a group "joking" about a student's food and accent. He laughs along, then goes quiet. Recognise: laughing along is not the same as being OK.
2. **Turn 1: Engage:** name it calmly to the group: "Comments about someone's heritage aren't jokes here. Stop, please." Later, a private check-in with him: "Tell me how things are with that group."
3. **Turn 1: Support:** he says "it's fine, it's just banter". Don't argue with him. Tell him he can come back to you any time, and that no one has to put up with comments about who they are.
4. **Turn 1: Notify:** pass it to the DSL the same day, and record it as a prejudice-related incident in line with school policy. One observation is often the first piece of a pattern.
5. **Turn 1: Document:** GOLD. The exact words, in quotation marks, in the record only; who was present, how he reacted, and what you did.
6. **Turn 2: break time (three weeks later):** At break, a student uses racist slurs at him in front of a crowd. Some are laughing; one is filming. He is upset and silent. Recognise: this is racist abuse, and it is public.
7. **Turn 2: Engage,** if it is safe to do so: "Stop. That language is racist and it stops now." Move between them if you safely can. Tell the crowd to move on and the phone to go away. Send a student for a colleague.

8. **Turn 2:** Support him first: "I heard what was said. That was racist, and it's not your fault. Come with me somewhere quieter." Your calm is contagious. A colleague stays with the other student.
9. **Turn 2: hold:** Pause for 90 seconds, then Three Lenses. Hold here on purpose: no lecture in front of the crowd, no "shake hands", no interrogation of witnesses. Ask whether anything like this has happened before.
10. **Turn 2:** Offer: model alternatives and explain what happens next. Options, not orders: who he'd like with him, whether he wants to go back to lessons now, and how his parents are told.
1. **Turn 2:** Notify: the DSL, the same day, in person. Mention the filming and the earlier "jokes". The DSL links this to the Turn 1 record.
2. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD. The exact words, in quotation marks, in the record only; who was present; the filming; what you did.
3. **Turn 3: online (that evening):** A clip of the incident appears in a year group chat with racist comments added. Because both earlier concerns were recorded, the DSL can see the pattern straight away.
4. **Turn 3: loop back:** Loop back to Recognise: now there is a pattern, an audience and a recording. A pattern helps explain, but nobody waited for it: action was taken the first time.
5. **Turn 3:** Support: check in with him again, and review the support plan. Does he feel safe coming in? What would help at break and on the way home?
6. **Turn 3:** Notify: the DSL, the same day. The DSL decides how the clip is handled, considers the police, and plans responses for the students who filmed and shared it.
7. **Turn 3:** Document: GOLD, linked to the earlier records, so the chronology is visible.

Wider spiral

Racist abuse in public involves more than two students. One incident, three strands moving at once.

1. **Three strands:** A student is racially abused at break. Another student used the slurs; a crowd watched, some laughing, one filming. A single concern traces a tight spiral; this one is wider.
2. **At the same time:** Support the student targeted first. The student who used the language is taken somewhere separate by a colleague: calm, clear, no debate. A bystander who looks shaken is noticed and checked on.
3. **Joined up:** Offer, once the DSL has decided: support and choices for the student targeted; accountability and education for the student who used the language; for bystanders, what they can do next time, if it is safe to do so.
4. **Every strand:** Every strand ends in Document. The crowd's part is part of the pattern, and belongs in the record.

When it breaks

The same Year 9 student and the same break time, when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** A member of staff on duty hears the slurs. Recognise happens.
2. **Support skipped:** The adult says, "Right, both of you, pack it in," and walks on. No one checks on the student targeted. He hears that he was part of the problem.
3. **Pause skipped:** Later the adult makes the two students shake hands and say sorry in front of the group. Pause is skipped: the student targeted had no choice, and the crowd learns that racist abuse ends in a handshake.

4. **Notify and Document skipped:** Nothing reaches the DSL, and nothing is recorded. When the clip appears online, there is nothing to connect it to.
5. **The helix fragments:** The abuse continues online and in corridors. He stops coming to break, then stops telling. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

R

RECOGNISE: Identify the Harm and the Risk

Racist language is abuse, not a disagreement. Recognise what you are seeing, who is affected, and whether this is the first sign or part of something bigger.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Who used the language, who was targeted, who was watching, laughing or filming? Is a group involved?

Places

Break, lunch, corridors, changing rooms, the bus, sports fixtures, the boarding house: the less supervised spaces

Platforms

Group chats, memes, clips of the incident, gaming voice chat, online content being repeated

Patterns

Earlier "jokes"? The same students, the same target, or several targets? Linked to news events? Getting worse?

What Racist Abuse Can Look Like

Words

- Racist slurs and names, including "reclaimed" words used against someone
- Mocking an accent, name, food, clothing, hair or skin colour
- Stereotypes presented as jokes, or "where are you really from?" used to exclude

- Telling someone to "go back" somewhere

Actions and Content

- Gestures, symbols or graffiti with racist meaning
- Touching or pulling hair, or religious dress such as a headscarf or kippah
- Leaving someone out because of who they are
- Racist memes, clips or comments shared online

Faith-targeted abuse often overlaps with racism: antisemitic "jokes" and conspiracy theories, or slurs linking Muslims with terrorism. KCSIE 2026 names faith-targeted abuse alongside racism (paragraph 37), and the law treats racial and religious hostility together (Crime and Disorder Act 1998, section 28).

Signs in the Student Targeted

- Freezing, going quiet, looking down, or laughing along to get through it
- Later: avoiding break, the bus or particular students; changes in attendance, mood or concentration
- Hiding parts of their identity: changing how they speak, dress or wear their hair, or using a different name
- Saying "it's fine" or "it's just banter", often to avoid making it worse

Signs in the Student Using the Language, and in Bystanders

- Performing for an audience; looking to peers for approval
- Repeating language, "memes" or ideas that sound as if they come from online content
- "It's a joke", "everyone says it", "they don't mind", or "I can't be racist, I'm also..."
- Bystanders laughing, filming, looking away, or looking frightened, especially those who share the targeted student's background

No Disclosure Needed

You heard it yourself. You don't need the student targeted to complain, confirm or "make a statement" before you act and report. Many young people don't report racism because they expect nothing to happen, or fear it will get worse. KCSIE 2026 reminds all staff that even if there are no reports, it does not mean it is not happening (paragraph 33).

Behaviour, Child-on-Child Abuse, Hate Incident or Hate Crime? (England and Wales)

One incident can fall into several frames at once. Leave the decisions to the DSL and, where relevant, the police.

Frame	What it means	Who decides
Behaviour and bullying	Racist language breaks every school's behaviour policy. Where it is repeated, or part of a power imbalance, it is also prejudice-based bullying, which the behaviour policy should address (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 11 and 123).	The school, under its behaviour and anti-bullying policies
Child-on-child abuse	A safeguarding category, not a crime. KCSIE 2026 lists "discriminatory behaviour, including racism, faith-targeted abuse, and other prejudice-based incidents" (paragraph 37). It should never be passed off as "banter" or "just having a laugh" (paragraph 193).	The DSL, under the child protection policy
Prejudice-related or hate incident	Terms many schools use for incidents motivated by prejudice, whether or not they are crimes; record them in line with school policy. Police are replacing "non-crime hate incidents" with a narrower recording system, kept separate from crime records (reforms announced 31 March 2026) (College of Policing).	The school records; the DSL decides on any wider action
Hate crime	Any criminal offence can be prosecuted as a hate crime where the offender demonstrated, or was motivated by, hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity (CPS). Criminal responsibility in England and Wales starts at 10 (GOV.UK).	The police and the Crown Prosecution Service, never school staff

- **Racially or religiously aggravated offences:** assaults, criminal damage, public order offences and harassment are aggravated where the offender demonstrates hostility based on the victim's membership (or presumed membership) of a racial or religious group, or is motivated by such hostility (Crime and Disorder Act 1998, sections 28 to 32).
- **Public order offences:** using threatening or abusive words or behaviour within the hearing or sight of a person likely to be caused harassment, alarm or distress (section 5), or threatening, abusive or insulting words with intent to cause harassment, alarm or distress (section 4A) (Public Order Act 1986).
- **Sentencing:** for other offences, courts must treat hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity as an aggravating factor (Sentencing Act 2020, section 66).

Staff should not decide whether an offence has been committed. Describe what you saw and heard, and report it to the DSL, who decides whether to involve the police. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

The School's Own Duties

- **Equality Act 2010:** race includes colour, nationality and ethnic or national origins (section 9). A school, including an independent school, must not discriminate against, harass or victimise a student (section 85). Conduct between students is outside its scope, but treating racist bullying less seriously than other bullying may itself be unlawful discrimination (DfE Equality Act advice).
- **Public Sector Equality Duty:** a legal requirement for state-funded schools, including academies (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 88 and 101), which makes good record-keeping and monitoring of abuse and harassment essential (paragraph 102). **Independent schools are not public authorities and are not covered by it;** the Equality Act's other duties still apply.
- **Anti-bullying:** maintained schools must have measures to prevent all forms of bullying (Education and Inspections Act 2006, section 89); independent school proprietors must ensure bullying is prevented, so far as reasonably practicable, through an effective anti-bullying strategy (Independent School Standards, paragraph 10).

What the Data Shows

71%

of hate crimes recorded by the police in England and Wales were race hate crimes (82,490 offences)

Home Office, 2025

19%

rise in religious hate crimes targeted at Muslims, compared with the previous year

Home Office, 2025

204

antisemitic incidents affecting people and buildings in the school sector in the UK in 2025

CST, 2026

Home Office figures are for the year ending March 2025, the latest release, and exclude the Metropolitan Police Service, whose data were not comparable that year; they are police-recorded crimes for all ages, not school incidents. CST figures are incidents reported to CST. Checked 28 September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: Stop It, Then Listen

You are the adult on the scene. Stop the abuse, if it is safe to do so, calmly and clearly, without repeating the words. Then turn to the student targeted.

In the Moment

- **Stop it, if it is safe to do so:** move into the space and use a calm, firm voice. "Stop. That language is racist, and it stops now."

- **Name it; don't repeat it:** "What you just said about [name]'s background", not the words themselves.
- **Move the audience:** "Everyone else, move on, please. Phones away." Don't ask for the footage or delete it; tell the DSL it exists.
- **Get help and separate, calmly:** send for a colleague so one adult can stay with each student. Don't debate or lecture in front of the crowd.
- **If there is a risk of violence:** get help straight away. Physical intervention is a last resort, only where reasonable and proportionate to prevent serious harm, in line with school policy (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 205). If anyone is in immediate danger, call 999.

With the Student Targeted

"I heard what was said. That was racist, and it's not your fault. You don't have to say anything now. Shall we go somewhere quieter?"

Later they may tell you more, for example:

"It's been happening since September. I just ignore it. If I say anything they'll say I can't take a joke."

The RESPOND disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **TED:** "Tell me what happened today." "Explain how long this has been going on." "Describe how it's been affecting you." Never "why": it can sound like blame.

Helpful

- "Nobody deserves to be spoken to like that."
- "What happened was racist. We take that seriously here."

Unhelpful

- "Let's all calm down." (treats them as equally involved)
- "Try not to let it get to you" or "Just ignore them." (minimising)
- "Are you sure that's what they meant?" (doubt)
- "Shake hands and move on." (forced reconciliation)

- "They'll be excluded for this." (a promise you can't keep)

With the Student Who Used the Language

- Keep it short and calm: "What you said was racist and caused harm. It's not acceptable here. I'm passing this on, and we'll talk about what happens next."
- If they say it was a joke: "It doesn't matter whether you meant it as a joke. It's the impact that counts."
- If they say they can't be racist because of their own background: "Anyone can use racist language, whatever their background. What you said targeted someone because of who they are."
- Don't debate, interrogate, or promise particular consequences. Note what they say.

If a Bystander Tells You Later

"Some of the boys in our year keep saying stuff about her religion. Today it was really bad. I didn't know what to do."

Thank them: telling is taking action. Use TED. Don't ask them to collect evidence or share clips. They may fear being targeted next: tell them you will pass it on carefully.



SUPPORT: Safety and Dignity First

Support the student targeted before anything else. Racist abuse attacks who someone is, in front of their peers. Your calm is contagious; connection before correction.

Safety Check

- "Are you hurt?" "Has anyone threatened you?"
- "Is there anywhere, or anyone, you're worried about for the rest of today, or on the way home?"
- "Is anything being shared online about this?"
- If there has been violence, a threat, or the student seems very distressed or unsafe, tell the DSL immediately.

Immediate Practical Support

- A quiet, private space and a trusted adult of their choosing; water; time
- Their choice about going back to lessons now or later, and who walks with them

- Dignity: don't walk them past the crowd, and don't make them retell it several times
- Keep the students apart for now, without restricting the student targeted unless they want that

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Allow processing time and a quiet space. Use clear, concrete language; avoid idioms and double questions.
- Some students may repeat language without understanding it; it still needs addressing, with teaching they can access.
- Use a professional interpreter where language is a barrier, never another student or a family member.
- Record any adjustments you made.

Support for Everyone Involved

Everyone involved needs a response, planned by the DSL with pastoral staff.

The Student Targeted

- A named trusted adult and regular check-ins
- Protection from retaliation, and a say in any changes
- Counselling or pastoral support if they want it

Bystanders

- A check-in, especially for those who share the targeted student's background
- Thanks for anyone who helped or told
- Follow-up, not public shaming, for those who laughed or filmed

The Student Who Used the Language

- Clear consequences under the behaviour policy
- Education about impact, and the chance to change

- Curiosity about what sits behind it: online content, peer pressure, their own experiences, home influences

P PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Act with composure. Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. Anger, or discomfort with talking about race, can push you off course.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is the student targeted safe now and on the way home? Threats, violence or retaliation? A clip circulating? A pattern, or extremist ideas?
Rights	The targeted student's right to safety, dignity and a say in what happens; the right of the student who used the language, who is also a child, to a fair response that holds them to account without being dehumanised
Resources	The DSL, pastoral and senior staff, the school counsellor, the police where relevant, and the safe adults in each student's life

What You Must Not Do

Don't Investigate

- You heard it: you don't need witness statements. Don't interrogate the crowd or ask students to write accounts

Don't Force Reconciliation

- No handshakes, apologies on demand, or "talk it out" today

- Restorative approaches may come later, only if the student targeted freely chooses them

Don't Promise Secrecy or Outcomes

"I can't keep this between us, because it's about your safety and wellbeing. I'll pass it to the DSL, whose job is to help. I'll tell you what's happening."

- Don't promise exclusion, or that they'll never see the other student again

Don't Minimise, Debate or Repeat

- Not "kids being kids", "they didn't mean it" or "it's just how they talk"
- Don't debate whether it "counts" as racist, and don't repeat the slur

Check Your Own Response

- Am I responding differently because of who the students are, or because one is "usually well behaved"?
- **Adultification bias:** children, disproportionately Black children, can be viewed and treated as older than they are, and seen as a threat rather than as a child who needs support (NSPCC Learning). Check this when a Black student is upset, angry or responds back.
- Am I hesitating because I'm unsure of my words, or because both students are from minoritised backgrounds? Act anyway: stop it, support, report.
- If it connects with your own experience, you are allowed to feel it. Keep to the steps, and get support afterwards. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.



OFFER: Model Alternatives

Offer proportionate options without coercion, explain what happens next, and model a different response to racism, for the student targeted, the student who used the language and everyone watching. If in doubt, N before O.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to tell our safeguarding lead, whose job is to make sure you're safe and supported. What happened will be recorded, and it will be dealt with; the school will decide what happens with the other student, and I can't promise a particular outcome. Your parents or carers will usually be told, and we'll talk with you about how. Someone will check in with you tomorrow. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "Who would you like to be with you now?"
- "Would you like to go back to lessons, or have some time first?"
- "What would help at break and lunch this week?"

Some things have to happen, such as telling the DSL. Where there is a choice, give it to them.

Model the Alternative

For Bystanders

- **Delegate:** get an adult, straight away
- **Distract:** interrupt, or give the student targeted a reason to leave with you
- **Delay:** check in with them afterwards
- **Direct:** "Not OK", only if it is safe to do so
- Don't laugh, film or share

For the Student Who Used the Language

- Accountability first: consequences under the behaviour policy
- Education about the history and impact of the words they used
- A chance to repair harm, but only in a way the student targeted agrees to

Restorative Approaches

A restorative meeting can help some students, but only if the student targeted **freely chooses** it, knows they can say no or stop at any time, and it is led by trained staff after safety has been secured. It never replaces recording, safeguarding or consequences, and saying no carries no cost.

Support in School and Beyond

- Counselling or pastoral mentoring; a regular check-in with a named adult
- Teaching that addresses racism without singling anyone out: RSHE covers protected characteristics and hate crime (RSHE statutory guidance)
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7



NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible, and the same day. Where there has been violence, a threat, or there is immediate risk, tell the DSL immediately. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Tell the DSL or a deputy in person where you can, then record.
- If the DSL is not available, go to a senior leader, or take advice from children's social care (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 61). Don't wait until the end of the week.

- Also follow the school's procedure for recording prejudice-related incidents; that record does not replace telling the DSL.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care if they believe a child is at risk.

What to Tell the DSL

- Who was involved, where they are now, and who is with them
- What was said and done, including the exact words, which you record in quotation marks
- How the student targeted responded, and what they said to you
- Who was watching, anyone filming, and anything already online
- Any earlier incidents you know of, and any threats or violence
- What you said and did, and what you told each student would happen next

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Actions

- Check the targeted student's safety today; plan support and protection from retaliation; check records for earlier incidents involving either student
- Decide how any clip or online content is dealt with, without staff viewing or sharing it more than needed; ask for it not to be shared further
- Consider the police where there may be an offence: violence, threats, harassment, or racially or religiously aggravated public order offences; the student and family can also report directly
- Where the police are involved, agree with them what is said to other families, and when, before any contact
- Consider what sits behind the behaviour: online influence, exploitation, or concerns at home; where there are signs of extremist ideology, consider the Prevent duty and a Prevent referral (KCSIE 2026, Annex A)
- Record the incident as child-on-child abuse and a prejudice-related incident, so patterns can be monitored
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Police (999 or 101)	Violence, threats, repeated harassment, or other possible offences; immediate danger; where the family wants to report. True Vision (police online hate crime reporting): report-it.org.uk , or call 101; in an emergency, call 999
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it; concerns at home, including where racist beliefs are linked to wider concerns about a child's care
Prevent (via local procedures)	Where the student's language or content suggests they may be being drawn into extremist ideology or support for terrorism
Family help; mental health services	Where a student or family needs extra support, or the student targeted shows significant or lasting distress

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Both families will usually be told the same day. First consider whether contact could increase risk: for example, where racist attitudes may come from home, or a family may react with violence or retaliation. Where it could, seek advice from children's social care or the police first. Talk with the student targeted about how their parents will be told, and use an interpreter where needed.

Parent contact: the student targeted

- "I'm calling about something that happened at break today. Another student used racist language towards [name] in front of other students. [Name] is safe and with us, and did nothing wrong."

- "We're taking it seriously and following our procedures. We'll let you know what we can about next steps. Please talk to us before contacting the other family or posting about it."

Parent contact: the student who used the language

- "I'm calling about something that happened at break today. [Name] used racist language towards another student. This is serious, and we are following our behaviour and safeguarding procedures."
- "We also want to understand what's behind it, and to help [name] learn from it. Can we meet to talk it through?"

D

DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using **GOLD**. Accurate records let the DSL see patterns, and may be used by other agencies, including the police.

GOLD

Ground

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

Do

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words and What You Saw

- Heard at 10:52, near the canteen doors: [Student A] said "[exact words as heard]", directed at [Student B], twice, and told [Student B] to "go back to [country]".

- [Student B] looked down and did not respond. Around 12 students were watching; several were laughing; one was filming on a phone.
- Afterwards, [Student B] said: "It's been happening since September. I just ignore it."
- When I spoke to [Student A], they said: "It was a joke. Everyone says it."

This guide describes slurs rather than writing them out. **Your safeguarding record is different: write the exact words used, in quotation marks, however offensive.** The DSL, and possibly the police, need them to judge whether the abuse was racial, religious or both. Don't repeat them anywhere else.

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: RACIST LANGUAGE (CHILD-ON-CHILD; PREJUDICE-RELATED INCIDENT)

Date, time and place:

Recorded by: name and role

How it came to my attention: witnessed / told by:

Student targeted: name, year

Student(s) who used the language: name(s), year

WHAT WAS SAID AND DONE (exact words in quotation marks, however offensive):

TYPE: race / faith / both / other (as described, not assumed)

HOW THE STUDENT TARGETED RESPONDED; WHAT THEY SAID (their words):

WHAT THE STUDENT WHO USED THE LANGUAGE SAID (their words):

BYSTANDERS: approximate number, names if known, laughing / filming / helping

ONLINE: any filming, sharing or posts known of

THREATS, VIOLENCE OR EARLIER INCIDENTS: yes / no / details

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):

SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)

THE STUDENT'S WISHES AND VIEWS:

Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Labels about either student ("a racist", "a troublemaker", "oversensitive")
- Guesses about a student's ethnicity, religion or family views: record only what they told you
- Your emotional reaction ("I was disgusted")
- Copies of any clip, unless the DSL has decided that is how evidence is kept

Online Spillover and Influence

Racist abuse rarely stays in the playground. It is filmed, shared and fed by content students see online.

- **Clips and group chats:** an incident filmed at break can be shared within minutes, with more abuse added. Ask whether anything is being shared; tell the DSL; never forward or copy it yourself.
- **Online influence:** KCSIE 2026 lists racism, antisemitism, radicalisation, extremism and conspiracy theories among the "content" risks of online safety (paragraph 165). A student repeating racist memes or "facts" may be being drawn in, not only misbehaving. Be curious: "Tell me where you've heard that."
- **Extremism:** most racist language is not extremism. Where a student expresses support for extremist groups or violence, tell the DSL, who considers the Prevent duty (KCSIE 2026, Annex A). Educate Against Hate has resources for staff and parents.
- **Events in the news** can lead to spikes in racist and faith-targeted abuse. Check in with students who may be targeted.

Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home. A student targeted by racism may share a house, a table or a room with the student who targeted them.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Use the 4 Ps for the house: dorms, meals, common rooms, evenings, house group chats. Notice a boarder who eats alone or avoids the common room.
● Engage	Stop it, if it is safe to do so. Boarders often tell house staff at informal times; use TED and the script, in a visible space.
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: who they share with, who is on duty, and how they reach staff at night. Any changes to rooms or tables should not fall on the student targeted unless they want them.
● Pause	The student who used the language may live in the same house. Don't investigate or hold house meetings about the incident without the DSL's plan.
● Offer	Model alternatives: house expectations about language, respect and group chats; older boarders as role models. If in doubt, N before O.

Step	In boarding
● Notify	Tell the on-call DSL the same evening; immediately where there may be immediate risk, including at night. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
● Document	Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A house log or handover note is not a substitute.

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

Boarders must not be discriminated against, including because of their cultural or linguistic background (NMS 3.1), and a boarding school's anti-bullying strategy should reflect that boarders cannot escape bullying by going home (NMS 16.1 and 16.3). Ask international boarders who they would like to talk to.

Identity and Intersecting Harm

Racism often combines with other parts of who a student is. See the whole child.

- **Faith:** antisemitism and anti-Muslim hatred are faith-targeted abuse, and often racial too. KCSIE 2026 names faith-targeted abuse as child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37). Never ask students to answer for world events. Families may wish to report to CST or Tell MAMA.
- **Sex and gender:** racist abuse can be sexualised, for example comments about the bodies of Black or Asian girls, or racist stereotypes of boys. Where it is sexual, KCSIE Part five applies alongside this guide.
- **Within and between minoritised groups:** racism can happen within the same group (for example, about skin tone) or between different minoritised groups. The response is the same: whoever said it, stop it, support, report.
- **Nationality and language:** abuse about accents, names or where someone is "from" is racist. International, EAL, and Gypsy, Roma and Traveller students may be less likely to report.

- **Adultification:** Black students who are targeted may be seen as older, stronger or more to blame, especially if they respond angrily. Treat them as children who need support (NSPCC Learning).

When Staff Are Targeted, or Involved

- If a student directs racist language at you, you can respond using the same steps: stop it, keep yourself safe, and get a colleague. Tell your line manager and the DSL, record it, and ask for support. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.
- If a member of staff uses racist language to or about students, report it to the headteacher (or, if it concerns the headteacher, the chair of governors or proprietor), in line with the staff behaviour policy and KCSIE Part four.

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, this is the place to start.** See also Childline: racism and racial bullying.
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Call Hate Out (Stop Hate UK, for under-18s): confidential 24-hour support if you experience or see hate, in the areas Stop Hate UK covers (check at stophateuk.org)

For Parents and Carers

- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- Stop Hate UK: 0800 138 1625, 24 hours, confidential, independent reporting and support, in the areas where it is funded (check your area at stophateuk.org)
- Tell MAMA (anti-Muslim hate): 0800 456 1226 or report online at tellmamauk.org; confidential, and not a replacement for the police

- Community Security Trust (CST) (antisemitism): report online at cst.org.uk/report-incident, or call its 24-hour national number, 0800 032 3263
- True Vision (police online hate crime reporting): report-it.org.uk, or call 101; in an emergency, call 999

For Staff

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Anti-Bullying Alliance, *Racist and faith targeted bullying*
- Department for Education and Home Office, *Educate Against Hate*
- Department for Education, *Preventing and tackling bullying* (advice, 2017; current on GOV.UK)
- Department for Education, *The Equality Act 2010 and schools* (departmental advice, May 2014; referenced in KCSIE 2026, paragraph 96)
- NSPCC Learning, *Safeguarding children from Black, Asian and minoritised ethnic communities* (updated July 2025)

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- Equality Act 2010, section 9 (race)
- Equality Act 2010, Part 6, section 85 (schools: pupils)
- Education and Inspections Act 2006, section 89 (behaviour policy: preventing all forms of bullying)
- Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, Schedule 1, paragraph 10 (anti-bullying strategy)
- Crime and Disorder Act 1998, sections 28 to 32 (racially or religiously aggravated offences)
- Public Order Act 1986, Part I (sections 4, 4A and 5)
- Sentencing Act 2020, section 66 (hostility as an aggravating factor)
- Crown Prosecution Service, *Hate crime*
- GOV.UK, *Report hate crime*
- GOV.UK, *Age of criminal responsibility*

Figures and Practice

- Home Office, *Hate crime, England and Wales, year ending March 2025* (published 9 October 2025; latest release)
- Community Security Trust, *Antisemitic Incidents Report 2025* (published 11 February 2026)
- College of Policing, *Major reforms for police hate incident recording* (31 March 2026)

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- Racist or faith-targeted words, "jokes", gestures or content
- A silent or laughing target is not an OK target
- Child-on-child abuse (KCSIE paragraph 37), and possibly a hate crime
- No disclosure needed, and no need to wait for it to happen again

Respond

- Stop it, if it is safe to do so; name it, never repeat it
- Move the crowd on; phones away; get a colleague
- Student targeted first: "That was racist, and it's not your fault."
- No debate, forced apology, investigation or promises

Notify

- DSL as soon as is practicably possible, the same day

- Violence, threats or immediate risk: DSL immediately; immediate danger: 999
- Mention the filming, the crowd and earlier incidents
- The DSL decides about police, parents and Prevent

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- What was said and done, who saw, how the student responded
- Record as a prejudice-related incident too, in line with policy

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 1

Scenario 1: Student Using Racist Language Toward Another

© 2026/27 | **RESPOND** Safeguarding Framework

Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | Equality Act 2010 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.